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Understanding what goes on in the heart and the mind: learning about diversity and co-existence through storytelling

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Abstract

In work on cultural difference, personal stories are powerful means of becoming aware of the taken-for-granted arrangements of one's own culture, of piercing walls of hostility and of coming to understand other cultures. This article examines an experience with narrative and storytelling in a workshop on coexistence in a teacher education setting in Israel. Drawing on student writing and the instructor's journal, the account highlights the Arab and Jewish student teachers' experiences in the encounter, focusing on how they storied and restoried their understandings of 'what goes on in the heart and the mind' of the Other. © 2001 Elsevier Science Ltd. All rights reserved.

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1. Introduction

Teaching and learning, according to Dewey, are "a continuous process of reconstruction of experience" (Dewey, 1938). In recent years the value of taking a narrative perspective towards this reconstruction has become established; researchers have discovered the 'added value' of paying attention to the plots and storylines, noticing the language, and listening to the voices in which teachers and learners tell about their lives, their work, and their experience (Brown & Gilligan, 1992; Carter, 1993; Connelly & Clandinin, 1990; Elbaz, 1991; Mishler, 1986). Engagement with narrative also influences practice. The example of two experienced

history teachers provided by Gudmundsdottir (1991) suggests that because these teachers have paid attention to their personal stories and have found or created a way to integrate them into their curriculum, they are more adept at engaging with the concerns of their students. Connelly and Clandinin (1990) tell us that "learners, teachers and researchers are storytellers and characters in their own and others' stories;" we need to pay attention to our own stories as teachers if we are to be able to attend to the stories of pupils. This is the case at all levels of education. A beginning teacher educator, Collay (1998), weaves the story of her own learning to teach teachers into an account of the learning processes of new teachers, showing how the stories illuminate one another. Carter (1990) demonstrates the usefulness of metaphor and case stories in looking at student teachers' work in the practicum.

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Narrative tools such as journal writing (Diamond, 1994; Heikkinen, 1998) have become prevalent in teacher education programs, and we are gradually gaining an understanding of how these uses of storytelling and narrative actually function.

One strand of work which shows particular promise is work on cultural difference and diversity. The potential of personal stories and narratives for piercing walls of estrangement and hostility is not difficult to grasp. First of all the personal story is a powerful means of becoming aware of the taken-for-granted arrangements and constraints of one's own culture; for example, Haug (1987) demonstrates how 'memory work' allows women's experience of the socially ordered process of becoming female to surface. Storytelling can make it possible for members of marginalized groups to claim the voices silenced by mainstream culture (McLaughlin & Tierney, 1993); at the same time, storytelling can be a way of admitting the other into one's world and thus of neutralising the otherness and strangeness. Further, in telling stories about one's life, one is exposing the self to the view of others, implicitly allowing that the self-created by one's culture may not be the only one possible; Conle (1996) shows how the attention paid to stories of difference helped prospective teachers relate to one another and to their own experiences more reflectively. She found that in sharing stories a process of 'resonance' develops in which one participant's story triggers memories of similar incidents in other members; what is shared may be the emotion generated, the configuration of the situation, the problem confronted or its solution. The resonance among the various stories enables colleagues to participate in one another's experience.

However, the process of learning about diversity through narrative is by no means a straightforward and linear one, particularly in group settings such as a school or university. In Berlak's (1997) account of a small and diverse group of prospective teachers in a course on cultural diversity, we see how some of the participants were opened up by the experience to their own racist views, while others appeared to be unchanged by the class; one student reported powerful new understandings but still feared "becoming numb again". Fine's (1997)

account of preparing teachers for peacemaking stresses the need for both experienced and student teachers working together to continually 'shape and reshape' practice. Conle (1999) draws attention to the diverse interpretations that observers make of classroom events, and underlines the fact that each observer brings his or her own personal stories to the setting and draws on them, sometimes unaware, even in perceiving and reporting on what was observed. Garcia Coll, Cook-Nobles, and Surrey (1997) describe the range of issues, the emotionality and the struggle of an evolving encounter among just three women of different backgrounds, colleagues who came to the endeavour committed to go the distance together. This work underscores the enormous complexity of encounters of diversity in classroom situations and the need for close and careful reading of them; no single plot line will be adequate to capture the full story, especially where issues of difference and multiculturalism are being treated.

In the present article I examine an experience with narrative and storytelling in a situation of conflict and diversity. The Coexistence Workshop is a course in the teacher education program of the University of Haifa Faculty of Education. During the past 2 years I have taught the course three times to groups of 30–35 students, drawing on a variety of means to help students tell their own stories and engage with the stories of others in the class. In this article I will focus on my first experience with the course, a narrative that I have been storying and restorying in the light of later experiences.¹ I find that the account needs to be told as a story with a single plot line and a structure of problem or conflict and its resolution (Mishler, 1986), although an alternative plot is suggested at one point. To remind myself and the reader that this plot is not the only one possible and that it is to some degree

¹ Illustrations presented here all come from this particular class, but data from two later sections of the course and the written work of about 100 students provide background and additional points of reference. All the students gave permission for the use of their written material; names, place names and some other details have been changed to protect the anonymity of both students and those they interviewed.

an artifice imposed on the events, I will use brief narrative ‘interruptions’ to make this imposed order entirely obvious.²

“You’d understand what I’m talking about if you lived as an Arab, that’s the only way you could really understand what goes on in the heart and the mind”. This is what one of the students in the course was told by a family friend whom he interviewed. It is both a poignant and a challenging statement: perhaps we can never truly understand the experience of a member of another culture. It may also be an expression of the inevitable feelings

of alienation and separation experienced by a member of a group that feels excluded from the mainstream of society. The purpose of the course is to help Jewish and Arab prospective teachers understand the experience of the ‘other’ group, on the assumption that such understanding will contribute to coexistence and the development of a culture of peace. It is not really possible to live as the other, but through telling and listening to personal and communal stories, the course aims to provide a glimpse of what goes on in the heart and the mind. My purpose here is to tell the story of the course and through the telling begin to formulate the understandings that were reached.

² Thanks to a thoughtful and critical reviewer of this article (who read it as personal narrative rather than scholarship), I was made to think more deeply about the methodological underpinnings of this article. I write here from the position of a teacher educator who is trying to make sense of a classroom experience, and with the emphasis on my experience it is indeed a personal narrative. Placing the emphasis on ‘making sense’, however, the method is close to what Polkinghorne (1995) calls ‘narrative analysis’ and Clandinin and Connelly (2000) call ‘narrative inquiry’: an attempt to make sense of observed and experienced phenomena by crafting a story. Unlike a traditional researcher I did not choose or design the course experience with research in mind. However, like a ‘narrative inquirer’ I did write and collect ‘field texts’: I kept a journal during the course, wrote an account which I gave to students during the course, and at the end of the course carried out an anonymous written evaluation and asked students for permission to keep and quote from their written assignments. Unlike a traditional researcher I did not bring to bear a particular theoretical framework either before the course began or afterwards when I began analyzing the experience, though I did use various theoretical perspectives to make sense of what happened, to raise questions and to check my ongoing interpretation. I quote from student writing to bring evidence of processes where I see students storying and restorying their experience, and almost always *they* are the ones who say directly that they learned something they were not aware of before. It’s true that I don’t quote examples of student writing where restorying does not happen. This is not because I want to distort the picture, but rather because such passages would be almost impossible to interpret: the fact that I don’t see restorying may be because I don’t know the student well enough. The aim of this work is not to arrive at generalizations that have predictive value in relation to future events, but rather to find or create meanings in relation to past and present experience, meanings which may enrich and empower us as educators going into future experience. The story structure which I suggest is one which provides me as a teacher educator (and hopefully other teacher educators in similar situations) with guidance and a degree of hope along with continued questioning and criticism of the course, my work and the process as a whole.

2. Learning coexistence in the university: story of a workshop

A couple of years ago I started to teach a course called the Coexistence workshop ...

The University of Haifa is located in the north of Israel, and close to 20% of the student body comes from the Arab community—Moslem, Christian, Druse, as well as other smaller groups whose first language is Arabic. Relations among Jewish and Arab students at the university are generally polite but distant; in courses it has been my experience that unless actively encouraged, only a minority of participants make the effort to get to know students from the ‘other’ group. Over the years I tried to bridge this distance, mainly by raising questions about cultural difference and arranging small group formats where students would have to communicate with each other in order to respond to the questions. My success was limited and sporadic at best. The Coexistence workshop was originally a required course for all teachers in training but in recent years it has become an elective because of funding difficulties. Over the years the workshop was taught by different teachers, using a variety of approaches. This diversity is valuable, and in itself sends an important message to student teachers; in describing my own approach to the course I am not suggesting that it is the ‘right way’ to teach the workshop. However, evidence

does suggest that just being together and discussing common issues is not enough to overcome barriers; engaging students in common tasks related to their professional goals has been shown to be an effective way of removing barriers to communication and creating relationships (Kalekin-Fishman, 1992, 1994). In planning my section of the coexistence workshop for the first time, I hoped to use personal writing and storytelling about their backgrounds as learners, their decision to become teachers and their experiences of the teacher education program as the common ground for enabling the students to get to know one another.

Although I was familiar with the students in the diploma programs, I was unsure about how they would react in the format of the coexistence course. Would they want to use it to express political opinions, to engage in argument, to vent strong feelings of anger, fear, frustration? I spoke with colleagues who had taught the workshop before but did not develop any expectations of what it might be like. I hoped that the workshop would become their space, that students would take responsibility for what happened in the group and use it to further their own needs, but knowing the students I did not count on this happening. So I developed a plan according to which there would be weekly topics and we would divide into small groups to either write or tell stories about the given topic; eventually I hoped that students could use one another's stories to write papers on the various topics.

I should acknowledge that I came to the course with some personal concerns. Not having grown up in Israel, I am not always comfortable with the no-holds-barred style of political argumentation that is typical of Israeli culture. I was hoping that the format of personal storytelling, in addition to its other merits, would provide a detour around what I thought of as futile political/intellectual argumentation. I believed that it was important to foster open communication and expression of feelings, but I was not sure what I would do if extreme views or strong feelings arose.

The workshop began smoothly enough ...

Over the first few weeks the course proceeded according to plan; small groups formed and a pattern of sharing stories was established. Several mixed groups seemed to 'click', whereas other students got together in all-Jewish or all-Arab groups and might have continued that way without my intervention. Attendance seemed to be somewhat irregular but participants had lively conversations and engaged in the tasks at hand. They discussed the decision to become teachers, influential teachers from their past, and similar topics, and the atmosphere gradually warmed up over the weeks.

and then things got complicated—in fact, they blew up!

On the fifth week of the semester as I walked through the lobby of the building where our class met, I noted an exhibit of caricatures that was sponsored by the Arab Students' Association of the University. I didn't have time before class to stop and find out about it; I thought that I would take a look during the break, and perhaps we would end class a bit early and go to look at the exhibit. I thought a visual stimulus would be an interesting complement to our focus on narratives.

Halfway through class I went out to check with the small groups that were meeting outside our classroom in the open sitting area. Near the exhibit I saw a large crowd of people and as I approached I was bombarded with sounds of yelling and shouting. In the middle of the crowd a reporter and cameraman were interviewing students, while small groups were arguing loudly all around me. One of the Jewish students came up to me, visibly upset, and informed me that the caricatures were very inflammatory, that they constituted incitement to violence, and that there was no Hebrew translation of the Arabic captions under most of the caricatures; her final comment was, "if they can mount an exhibit like this, they don't want peace".

I was sure this was going to be a disaster ...

My first reaction was one of despair; around me I saw many of the students in the workshop

engaged in heated argument, and I feared that the gradual understanding and common language we had been building up over the previous weeks was being destroyed. I went about finding the students and asking them to return to class even though they still had 10 or 15 min left on the time allotted for their small group discussions. I returned to class and we waited as students gradually returned, bringing the heated discussion with them.

When almost everyone had returned I asked them to speak about what had happened. Everyone seemed to have a lot to say and we now had only 15 min till the end of class. Spontaneously I suggested that rather than going into ideas and beliefs we should confine ourselves to what we were feeling; I said that there seemed to be so many different opinions that there was little chance of coming to any common understanding, but perhaps there were not so many different feelings among us.

As people spoke the nature of the exhibit was clarified. The Arab students pointed out that there was a large poster in Hebrew explaining the exhibit and telling about the artist (in the commotion this poster would have been difficult to find). The caricaturist was Naji El Ali, a Palestinian artist who had died some years before the peace process began; most of his images reflected the period of the Intifada. Times had changed, and the caricatures did not necessarily reflect anyone's current opinions, but he remained an important cultural figure because of his ability to capture and express what people felt at the time. The Arab students explained how important it was for them to see a representative of their culture shown in the public space of the university; one or two said that this was so important to them that whether or not others could understand the exhibit was secondary. They expressed disappointment that the Jewish students did not seem willing to understand their need for cultural expression, and were angry at the suggestion that their right to free expression might be curtailed. The Jewish students were also angry and disappointed, but for different reasons. Some of them saw the exhibit as a political statement with a clearly anti-Jewish message (as reflected in

some of the images in the caricatures), one which would be particularly painful to people whose families had been victims of terrorist attacks. Some felt that it was—or should be—illegal to hold an exhibit without translation into Hebrew regardless of the purpose or message. And many also expressed their disappointment, like the student I quoted above, that the exhibit showed the Arab students were not interested in peace.

Given the strong feelings in class I was quite surprised that the discussion proceeded in a reasonably orderly way, with everyone listening attentively to one another (far from the norm for political conversations in Israel!). It seemed that the invitation to speak about feelings provided a clear and authentic focus for discussion and captured everyone's attention. Although time was limited every student who wished to speak was able to do so, with little or no interruption or discussion. We went a little over time, and people seemed rather subdued as they left the room.

but then I began to see it differently ...

After class I went back to the exhibit accompanied by an Arabic-speaking student who translated some of the captions for me; we found that many of them were tied to barely-remembered political events and were difficult to explain. The exhibit was no longer crowded, the press had left, and I spent some time watching people's interactions. A couple of students from our class were still there, continuing the discussion, which was still intense but much less angry. Two students, an Arab woman and a Jewish man, concluded their discussion and shook hands. A woman student from our class came up to me looking very excited and apologised for not having returned to class; "I couldn't leave," she said, "this was too important".

It was then that my own perspective on the event underwent a significant change. Previously I had looked upon this eruption of conflict as a completely negative event that disrupted the gradual process of coming to know one another that had been taking place in our class. But looking at the expressions on the faces of the students who had been in the center of the

conflict and worked out some kind of understanding, I began to see the value of engaging with conflict, of persisting in a difficult discussion with another person until some understanding (not necessarily agreement) is reached, a process which has been termed ‘sitting in the fire’ (Mindell, 1995). In the week that followed I wrote up a narrative account of what had happened, quoting as many of the comments as I remembered. In the light of my new perspective, I concluded the account with the idea that although the experience was a difficult one, it brought out issues that we must learn more about, and now that it’s over we are still here, realising that somehow we still need to figure out how to achieve coexistence.

We all began to restory the event ...

I handed out copies of my narrative account for discussion in the next class meeting. Some people clarified or explained what they had said the week before. I explained my view that the conflict had been a positive event because it allowed people to express themselves more fully and clearly and allowed all of us to see and understand each other better; not everyone agreed with me. However, near the end of the discussion someone repeated my conclusion: we are all still here, in class, needing to figure things out. At this point something new and interesting happened: various people started to comment and make suggestions about the situation and format of the class. “We don’t know each other’s names,” one student said. Someone else pointed out that it would be better to be sitting in a circle (I had not rearranged the seating previously because we had spent most of our class time in small groups), and I welcomed the suggestion. Several other students volunteered to lead activities to help people get to know each other; we acted on these suggestions in subsequent weeks. Someone brought up the idea of a class trip, and later in the semester this was organised by one of the students. Jewish and Arab students shared in taking responsibility for these activities.

From then on participants began to really get to know one another ...

My original plan for the course was shelved at this point. We devoted some of the remaining sessions to student suggestions, and some to narrative activities which I led. In the weeks that followed, we did not return to the heated argument and discussion that characterised the ‘blow up’, but we did have a variety of lively sessions in which everyone participated. We played some group games to get to know each other. Filling out an ‘identity card’, we had the opportunity to learn how each person defined him or herself and why; we visited a mosque and took a short hike to Elijah’s Cave, a site on the Carmel that is holy to all three religions. We brought ‘objects of value’ and shared the stories around them. We discussed our ancestors, people we admired, and found that many people, Arabs and Jews, shared special feelings for two role models in particular: their mothers, and the late Yitzhak Rabin. When the students responded to an evaluation of the course their comments were almost entirely positive; in the following sections I will discuss some of the specific outcomes of the course.

in the way that they participated in class ...

As mentioned, one of the most important outcomes of the course was the way that students began taking responsibility for what happened in the course. The eruption of conflict, and the experience of expressing their deepest feelings and listening to one another which followed, seemed to energise students to take responsibility for the workshop. Some of their suggestions were small but non-trivial, like the idea of arranging our chairs in a circle; others concerned practical activities to implement in the course. All of their suggestions were acted upon. Students also took more responsibility for their individual behaviour; when a trip was organised some students had difficulties attending because of conflict with other classes, and they made a special point of notifying me or one of the organisers.

as instructor I also changed ...

Another outcome of the course is undoubtedly the change that it brought about for me as

instructor. I mentioned the change in my perspective after the exhibit. Because I began to see conflict in a new way, I was motivated to learn more about conflict resolution³, and I also began studying Arabic (something I had wanted to do for a long time, but feared would be too difficult). It is apparent that the experience of teaching the workshop energised me, as it did the students, to take significant actions toward increasing my own competence to facilitate coexistence workshops, and to restore my own role in teaching for coexistence and peace.

In work they did after the workshop ended, the restorying continued ...

For the final assignment, I asked students to identify what would constitute for them the 'next step' in coexistence, and to take it; it might be a paper reporting on academic learning about the 'other' group, but it might just as well be a visit, an interview or another form of practical experience as long as they wrote it up and explained why it was, for them, the needed next step.

Of the 31 students who completed the course (2 dropped out along the way), 18 students wrote about a personal encounter with a member of the other group; of these, 10 conducted an interview or conversation with someone they already knew from the university or their place of work, while eight students used the assignment as an opportunity to revisit an experience they had had in the past. The remaining 13 students reported on an article or book they read related to an issue raised in class: e.g. the place of women in Arab culture, the way Arabs are represented in textbooks, or cross-cultural encounters. Most of them connected their reading in some way to events or people encountered in the course. Three of these 13 students wrote about their own group: one Arab student looked at literature on how Arabs are perceived by Jews, and two Jewish students read a book by a Jewish author

describing the experiences of Jewish immigrants. Almost all the assignments related to what I had described as the 'next step' in coexistence: most of them emphasised new learnings about the other group, notions they had held in the past that were changed by their reading or meetings. (It is possible that even the three students who wrote about discrimination within their own group were taking a step that was necessary for them at that moment.) At first I was disconcerted by the eight assignments that reported on a past experience, since these students did not appear to have made the effort to learn something new. However, after reading their assignments carefully I realised that these students too were engaged in restorying their experience in the light of what they had learned in the workshop. One student commented on the fact that her friendship with an Arab woman had been the subject of raised eyebrows among certain of her family members, and told how she now responded to this; several others examined their own stereotypes and how these had changed.

The students who went to talk with a friend were frequently surprised to learn things they had never suspected. Excerpts from their assignments reflect this new learning.

Michal: The story I want to tell reflects the living out of coexistence between myself and my neighbour across the hall who happens to be Arab. We have known each other since childhood ... we grew up in an open atmosphere, our parents related to each other as neighbours. The business of "Arabs and Jews" never existed for us ... Today, now that both of us have grown up and have our own world views, we often wonder what the two peoples are actually fighting about ... One day last week, in her home, I told her about the course ... We sat in her room, the TV was on, and we started to talk about different topics that came up in the course. During the conversation that developed, I discovered things that I had never known about her, things I couldn't believe existed in our town that has always had coexistence.

She told me that despite the coexistence she feels alienated and threatened. I asked in what

³In particular I make reference here to the approach to conflict work elaborated by Mindell (1995), known as 'world-work'.

way and she said that almost every day something happens to remind her that she is an Arab who is part of a minority in Israel. The last time this happened she was out for the evening with a friend and her older brother. The evening ended late and they were walking home. A police car stopped beside them and the policemen started to question them as to what they were doing out in the street so late. "It's amazing that in one second the whole evening's fun can be destroyed, a moment that creates unpleasantness and reminds us where exactly we belong". I claimed that the police always stop to question people who are out late at night, but she insisted it's not the same for Jews as for Arabs...

She loves the smells of Acco, the smell of the sea mixed with the city smells, and says that she will never leave the town... She and her family have adapted to a certain way of life and are resigned to the fact of alienation between the two peoples. Her father, who owns a business in town, lives a simple and ordinary life like my father. Our way of life is very similar, the problem is that if a Jew or an Arab looks at us and our way of life from outside they will always try to find the differences and not the similarities.

Michal writes with immediacy and sensitivity of the encounter with her childhood friend and neighbour. It is apparent that Michal knows her friend well, and yet her sadness and bitterness come as a surprise; the change in feeling tone that characterises Michal's new understanding of her friend's life as an Arab in Israel is an important kind of restorying that this excerpt makes evident. Reading her assignment one hopes that Michal's empathy for her friend will motivate her to learn more, and that she herself will not be 'resigned to the fact of alienation between the two peoples'.

Another student who was surprised by her discussion with a co-worker is Liora:

Liora: I met N at the pharmacy where I work. He is a pharmacist, 28 years old, and lives in a mixed neighborhood in Haifa. During the time we worked together we became friends, to the point that he asked me to babysit for his daughter when he and his wife needed to go out. I felt that

this showed the mutual trust that could develop between our two peoples, and between us in particular. I was invited to dinner and during the meal N. talked about his feelings as an Israeli Arab. He is very bitter about the discrimination that there is towards the Arabs in Israel. For example, in the past he lived in a village, only Arabs live there, and there are no roads, no sewage system, no soccer field, living conditions are difficult and not modern... although his relations with Jews at work and in his neighborhood are good, he would prefer to live in his own village... He said that his life is not so bad here, but he would prefer to live in Scandinavia or Italy...

In this excerpt the restorying is characterised by the addition of new information about the living conditions in a particular Arab village; the new information modifies Liora's understanding of the mutual trust that she and her friends have established, because she now sees that trust exists between them *despite* the discrimination and feelings of bitterness.

Ron talked with a family friend, his father's co-worker. He made a note of the fact that he did not introduce his own opinions into the discussion; he wanted to document Ahmed's views carefully, not discuss or argue about them.

Ron: Ahmed works in the factory where my father works, and I had the opportunity to sit and talk with him when he came to our house to pick up something. He lives in M____, he's 39, married and has five children.

Ahmed thinks of himself first of all as a person and as an Arab who lives in this country whose population is in the majority Jewish. He says that we are very similar peoples and we come from the same source, but history has created animosity and repulsion between the two sides. He feels this from the moment he leaves his home to come to work. A number of times he didn't have a car and he tried to hitchhike... cars wouldn't stop for him and a long time passed until someone from his workplace recognised him, or an Arab stopped for him... Sometimes on the bus people would examine him from head to toe during the trip, and he'd feel like a 'foreign body' among all

the people. He doesn't blame anyone, this situation will continue for many generations...he would like to show that it doesn't have to be this way, that the gulf can be bridged, but most of the people he knows—Jews and Arabs—have lost the energy and the hope to try where others have tried and failed.

The only place where he can find quiet and pleasure is in his home with his wife and children... He is worried that when his children grow up they will have to deal with the same problems...

I didn't go into political issues with Ahmed because the results of that argument are known in advance. We both knew that the moment we go our separate ways the bubble we created during our conversation about a better future, would burst...he said "You'd understand what I'm talking about if you lived as an Arab, that's the only way you could really understand what goes on in the heart and the mind".

In Ron's account we can see both the empathetic tone and the addition of much new information that appeared in the previous accounts; added here is a consideration of time and history. Ron stresses Ahmed's lack of hope for his children's future, and points out that their conversation about a better future is only a bubble that will burst the moment they end their conversation; but still it is a restorying that points toward the future, a vague and dim possibility but still a common future that might be realized.

Some of the students wrote about a new encounter; in effect, they were telling a new story. One of them, a Jewish student, told about making the discovery that an acquaintance with whom she worked, a Jewish woman student, was in a relationship with an Arab man. This student described her own upbringing as very traditional and said that she should have been shocked by her friend's revelation. However, since she knew and liked the boyfriend, also a coworker, she was able to listen and try to understand her friend's story and get to know the couple. This encounter triggered a significant restorying of her own understanding of coexistence which previously had not allowed for intermarriage or mixed relationships.

Two students made reciprocal visits to one another's homes, visits which gave them new understandings and also allowed for the envisioning of new stories.

Ela: We met on Tuesday afternoon at the entrance to the town, Nadim picked me up in the family car... His mother received us warmly with the greeting "Ahlan WaSahlan", my heart pounded with excitement but after a round of introductions I felt more relaxed...

Nadim: Ela invited me to Friday night dinner at her parents' home, and although she doesn't come from a religious family, there was something moving about the fact that it was Friday night and this was the first time that I was a guest in a Jewish home for a Sabbath meal... Ela's mother, a very friendly woman, seems to enjoy entertaining and especially on the Sabbath, and she surprised me with her command of Arabic, later I found out that Ela's parents came from Syria...

Ela told me about her military service, and her trip to the Far East. She showed me pictures which were amazing, I was surprised by her courage, and her mother told about the difficult time the family experienced while she was travelling. I would like to see this openness in my own community, so that one day any of the girls of the village could announce openly to her family that she is planning a trip abroad, just to discover new things, and this would be perfectly legitimate. Today this still seems far away because of the conservative approach of Arab culture.

This excerpt shows Nadim restorying both his understanding of Jewish culture and his view of his own culture. It also points to the gender issues which were present in many of the discussions and interactions, and which subtly influenced the story of the course although they were not often discussed. For example, some of the Arab women students described themselves as conservative and had a traditional view of their roles as women in Arab and Moslem culture. These women were prepared to share their ideas in small group discussions, particularly with other women students, but less often spoke in the large group. Other Arab women were

particularly vocal, described themselves as wanting to make changes in the school system and were ready to be leaders in our class as well. In the caricature episode, it seemed that many of the conversations took place between Jewish men and Arab women, and I wondered what gender and cultural issues were at work behind the scenes in those political discussions; this is a topic for future work.

Participating in the workshop was a challenge for all the students, but several were particularly courageous in addressing some of the difficulties they experienced in Jewish–Arab relations. One student examined her own racism, which had been acquired in the natural course of events. She retold an experience that enabled her to learn more about Jewish culture; what seems to be new in this retelling is her frank examination of the biases with which she grew up:

Rania: I live in the village of _____ where everyone is Moslem, and when everyone you know is of the same nationality and religion, you form ideas about other people ... I had no contact with the Jewish population except for superficial things like in stores or hospitals ... So I formed a general opinion about the Jews from the media, TV, radio and especially the Arab stations and the press. ... of course this opinion was a cruel and racist one because the media give the side they are interested in ... This prejudice started to change when I came to study at the University with Jews from many different places and backgrounds ... I wanted to take driving lessons and a friend told me that someone who studies sociology with us is a driving instructor ... I met a person with left-wing ideas, gentle and considerate ... we had many interesting conversations about social, political and cultural issues and I realised I had been 100% wrong when I generalised ... I also got to know the Jewish culture, the holidays and celebrations, the religious rituals ... he also got to know our holidays, the month of Ramadan and the fast ... and it was interesting for both of us ... I'm ashamed of the way I used to think and the prejudices I had about the other side. So people learn from their mistakes, right?

So I can say that the workshop was a success ...

Their stories show that many of the students were given a new picture of life in Israel. The case of those students who talked with people they already knew fairly well is particularly interesting. We can imagine that the experience of telling and listening to personal stories had made these students better not only at listening and telling but also at asking questions. Or perhaps their 'interviewees' could sense something new in their attitude or approach, something intangible which acted as a catalyst for the telling of a story that had not previously been told. However we explain it, it is apparent that these students were retelling their stories about coexistence in Israel. The new stories were more difficult and painful than the old stories, but more realistic and in that sense, more hopeful.⁴

Although for at least one participant—and perhaps others who remained silent—there was a totally different plot line ...

One student's learning from the course seemed more problematic: Nina discovered that coexistence was not the simple thing she had assumed in the past, and she was disturbed by some of the experiences of the course.

Nina: I decided to write about my personal history of coexistence. My father developed a friendship with a group of people from the Arab villages near where he worked. I was born into the fact of coexistence, of relationships with the other side. I remember visiting the village at Christmas, the tree, the smells of the food and the

⁴The aforementioned reviewer had "a hard time believing that a single course had as much impact as claimed on the political and personal lives of people who have known so much conflict". The evidence is in the students' writing. Unlike the positive evaluations at the end of the course (which are very general and probably say little about the real impact of the course), the assignments with their choice of detail and personal point of view do speak to the learnings that students took away with them. These outcomes are encouraging, but obviously they tell us little about the impact of this learning on the students' political and personal lives, on action in complicated life situations, or even about whether what was learned is remembered later on.

goat in the yard. Everything seemed natural and right ... The last time I saw our friends was at my wedding, I was excited to see them and they who had watched me grow up were excited to see me getting married.

A shift in my story came when I started the course. The first change was after the exhibit of caricatures ... The second change was during the activity when we filled out our “Identity cards” ... the differences in political views hit me like thunder: most of the Arab students didn’t see themselves as belonging to the State of Israel, but to the land of Israel, and they didn’t feel a connection to the flag of Israel or the leaders. They saw the rival Arab countries as their true nationality.

Since then I have been in a conflict I never expected ... As a child I saw the Arabs—our friends—as different from us in their culture, I saw them as friends, partners in the State not just physically but also mentally. I believed this view until the course began ... I have become aware that the cultural difference is not the problem, but rather the political claims of each side are different ... I felt that the Arab students in the course are under the jurisdiction of Israel unwillingly, they would rather be in Syria or Jordan. I wonder if our friends also feel this way, and if so then the friendship was not a true one because of the bitterness towards the Jews ... still I hope for a true peace between us ...

But I manage to incorporate it into my story of success ...

Nina’s story on first reading appears to take a negative turn: it seems that someone who previously saw coexistence as ‘natural and right’ now fears that her Arab friends have been hiding their bitterness and are not true friends. But she too is moving toward a more realistic view, although she is not yet aware of the degree to which “the tree, the smells of food and the goat in the yard” is a romanticised view of Arab village life in Israel. Her story was not presented in class but the reservations and confusion she experienced were certainly not hers alone. Her account introduces an additional element of restorying:

the critical dimension. Unlike many students who seemed to back away from the experience of strong conflict and sought out pleasant experiences with members of the other group, Nina was able to hold awareness of the real difficulties of achieving coexistence in a situation where there is a history of discrimination and feelings of bitterness.

... and keeping it in mind as a warning, I continue to teach the workshop to new groups of students, hopeful that it is making a very small but real contribution to prospective teachers’ understandings of diversity and coexistence.

3. Restorying our collective experience

Having told the story of the course, I want to consider what kind of learnings about diversity and coexistence it made possible. The group experience of the course was complex, and only a few vignettes have been presented here. It is apparent that the awkward and large group of students who gathered at the beginning of the semester underwent a significant transformation over the course of 14 weeks. In the early weeks I was uncomfortable each time we divided into small groups and I had to remind them to make sure that their group included both Arab and Jewish students. Some students also commented on this ‘labelling’ people as belonging to a particular group. Even after working in mixed groups had become routine, dividing into separate groups still happened occasionally, but by the end of the semester we could joke about it. At one of our last meetings quite a few people happened to be absent and as I went around the room asking particular individuals to change groups, I pointed out that the Arab students were a ‘scarce commodity’ which we’d have to share fairly. This progression indicates that interacting in mixed groups was gradually becoming the normal thing to do.

In their evaluations many students saw the fact that they had come to know students from the ‘other’ group as the main positive achievement of the course. I would not want to undervalue the importance of this ‘simple’ achievement—learning that a person from the other group is a person like

oneself and can be a friend. Surely it is a necessary first step. But the limitation of this outcome is clear: I may accept the ‘other’ so long as she appears to be just like me, but if I do not also have an appreciation of her difference, and of the fact that she is a person of value with and because of what makes her different from me, then my understanding of and readiness for coexistence will be very restricted. In order for more meaningful kinds of learning to take place, at least two more steps are necessary. First, it is essential that students become aware of and value diversity, in itself and for its own sake. Second, they need to acquire an understanding of differences in rank and privilege which people from different groups experience in society, and to see how all of us are complicit in these arrangements. So I was particularly attentive during the course to occasions when participants became aware of difference and to the implications of that awareness.

One important moment occurred during the ‘Identity Card’ exercise when students shared information about how they define themselves. All of us became aware of the many different ways the Arab students defined themselves, from “Israeli Arab” to “Palestinian who lives in Israel because of a historical accident” with many other options in between, as contrasted to the Jewish students whose definitions, and explanations of them, were much less diverse. As a group we did not go beyond this initial awareness, although individual students reflected on it as indicated by Nina’s writing quoted earlier. But there was a recognition of the complexity and difficulty of being an Arab in Israel though not always of how this translates into differences in privilege.

A personal moment of illumination occurred for me when a student responded to a question about “Another country you’d like to live in” by saying she would like to live in Syria; I found myself surprised by this and asked why, and she said simply that she had always been curious about Syria. Thinking about it later on, I became aware that my own image of Syria was formed entirely by the media, that I actually had very little idea about life there and that I had the privilege of not bothering to find out. In the final meeting I spoke about this event as one which had changed my own understanding and thanked the student. In doing so

I was modelling a process of self-examination which I hoped students would take from the course.

Another opportunity to see each other clearly with all our differences was provided by an exercise in which we shared objects of value that students brought to class. One student, a religious woman, showed us her Organ Donor Card and told the story of how she decided to join the organ donor program after her father died; Jewish religious law strongly values the sanctity of the body after death and while organ donorship is not against religious law since it saves life, it is not a common practice among observant Jews in Israel. In listening to Ayelet’s story we were provided with a moving example of her ability to look at her own unexamined assumptions and make a change; we were also reminded that all religious people do not necessarily think alike.

In the same exercise two Arab women brought identical objects, colourful hats bought on a trip to Turkey the previous summer. Travelling abroad without a male chaperone was something these women had to fight for; the pleasure of the trip was made even sweeter because they had struggled with their families and cultural prescriptions and won. They talked openly about what behaviours would be considered appropriate or inappropriate for women, and how this was slowly changing. We had the opportunity to see them as strong women who were thinking independently and trying to make changes in their community’s attitudes towards women while remaining within and respecting that community and its traditions.

I have presented these experiences of difference from my perspective and as I experienced them. In their writing and evaluations students also mentioned these experiences, but it is impossible to know *how* exactly they experienced them. The only thing one can be certain of is that everyone is likely to have experienced them differently (Conle, 1999). Hence the vital importance of ample space and time to share our experiences and perceptions.

Time, however, is limited; in order to use it to best advantage, in subsequent courses I have put more emphasis on issues of rank and privilege (Mindell, 1995). Students tell personal stories about their experiences of situations in which they had low or high rank, and hearing these stories (akin to

‘testimony’ as discussed by Conle, 1999) is a powerful way to take further our understanding of difference as being bound up with privilege, discrimination and differential opportunities. In recent courses I have also begun to see that taking the storytelling process further can lead to action; in one instance, a group of students circulated a petition requesting the university to honour Moslem and Christian holidays as part of the university calendar, while other students took small but still significant steps toward change: inviting a student of the ‘other’ group to share a cup of coffee in the cafeteria, or to visit one’s home.

4. Coda

In telling the story of the Coexistence workshop, I emphasised the process of restorying of individual and collective experiences of diversity and conflict as Arabs and Jews living together in Israel. There were two kinds of catalyst for the restorying: one was the sharing of personal stories around different topics over the semester, and the other was the larger story of relations between Jews and Arabs in Israel which was being lived out around us, specifically in the context of student life at the University. The retelling itself took a number of different forms: stories expanded to include new information, in particular the rich details of lived experience; there was a change in tone as stories were told from a position of greater empathy; the stories began to acquire the horizon of a common future; and a critical dimension made an appearance through the beginning awareness of discrimination and negative feelings. The story of the course itself points toward additional possibilities for teaching about diversity and coexistence using the students’ personal stories as a place to begin.

Storytelling has traditionally been associated with many kinds of life situations; often we tell stories just for fun and amusement, to pass the time, but there are also many images of storytelling as a tool for survival. The 1001 Nights comes to mind, as do images of travellers huddled around a fire on a ‘dark and stormy night’. In the Israeli context where achieving coexistence is both a vital task and test of democracy, and a precursor of the broader

peace process, telling our stories is indeed a matter of survival: only by telling and listening, storying and restorying, can we begin the process of constructing a common world.

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